

Standard Chartered Plc (HK) (2888)

Investor day reinforces our conviction - targets conservative, execution accelerating

Our takeaways from Day 1 of Standard Chartered's (STAN) Investor Day are positive. First, we believe STAN's ROTE target (>15% by 2028E) is relatively conservative in the current economic environment, considering the Group's growth momentum. There could be upside risk to our 2028E ROTE of 15.5%, as STAN targets building to an 18% ROTE by 2030. Second, we gained a better understanding of STAN's ROTE expansion strategy and how it intends to achieve it. This includes optimising client mix, such as focusing on Affluent clients within Wealth & Retail and FI/cross-border flows within CIB clients to drive ROTE expansion. Third, we gained insights into how STAN is leveraging technology and AI to safeguard the bank and improve operating leverage. With the seminars in Hong Kong still ongoing, we leave our forecasts unchanged.

- Conservative medium-term targets amid current growth momentum and favorable economic environment:** As discussed in our First Take [here](#), STAN has outlined its medium-term financial framework with targets to 2028 which are broadly in line with expectations although conservative, in our view. **1)** RoTE of >15% by 2028 (vs 11.9% FY25 and JPMe 15.5% 28E), building to ~18% by 2030 which we believe is realistic; **2)** high-teens 25-28E EPS CAGR (vs JPMe c18%) and a 5-7% income CAGR (vs JPMe 5.6%); **3)** cost-to-income ratio of ~57% by 2028 from 63% in 2025 (vs JPMe c56% 28E), supported by positive income-to-cost jaws each year; **4)** CET1 ratio operating range of 13-14% although with intention to operate at the mid-point on average; **5)** dividend payout ratio of ≥30% with progressive DPS (vs JPMe 35%).
- Business mix to drive +380bps ROTE uplift:** The Group's focus on Affluent (within Wealth & Retail) and Cross-border/Financial Institutions (within CIB) offers more attractive income/RWA metrics than other customer segments. Based on disclosed data, we calculate that PB (AUM>US\$10mil) and priority private (\$1mil<AUM<\$10mil) income per client is 218x/44x times higher than premium (\$25k<AUM<\$100k). And FI business RoRWA was 190bps higher than that of corporate in 2025. These segments are also faster-growing with stronger operating leverage. Within this, asset/liability optimisation of surplus liquidity is targeted to drive +50bps ROTE and support NIM. While STAN's deposit franchise has traditionally been weaker compared to peers, we see undiscounted value in growth trends as the business focuses on quality deposits.
- The third-largest Wealth Manager in Asia, within that, PB AUM ranks #5 in Asia:** STAN's net new money and AUM growth has

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Overweight

2888.HK, 2888 HK

Price: HK\$198.00

20 May 2026

Price Target: HK\$275.00

PT End Date: 31 Dec 2026

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outpaced peers in recent years, leading it to become the third-largest WM in Asia (vs 5th in 2020) with \$422bn in AUM. The Group is focused on quality client acquisition, particularly International and HNW clients, and on internal uptiering which offers a significant source of AUM growth. International clients (c400k clients) with accounts in >3 markets typically have c3x more AUM than single-market clients. Priority Private (within HNW, AUM >\$1mil) offers the highest returns, with c75% of clients uptiered internally which has driven a 3x increase in AUM post-uptiering (vs pre-uptiering) from 2023 to 2025, a 1.7x increase in client base and NNM +10x. The Group is also the fifth-largest PB in Asia (up from #8th in 2023) with the UHNW client base growing by 80% in the last 2Y and clients' NNM up 2 times. There are also strong cross-selling economics between divisions: 1) PB clients with CIB relationships generate 4x AUM than standard PB clients; 2) Affluent clients with SME relationships have 5x more AUM compared to standard Affluent clients. Relationship managers have grown 18% over the last 2Y with one-third coming from internal referrals, alongside 40% growth in senior RMs. The Group remains focused on further pivoting towards Affluent clients, away from mass-market, single-product relationships. STAN has set new targets for affluent client growth, committing to a double-digit CAGR in wealth income, which it targets will make up 75% of WRB income by 2028 (vs 70% in 2025), please see Figure 1 for details.

- **Originate to Distribute (O2D) focus in the CIB:** Financial Institution income/RWA was 8.0% in FY25 compared to 6.1% for Corporates, both of which have grown from 7.2%/4.4% respectively in FY19. The growth target for origination volume is a 10% CAGR, while for distribution volume it is a mid-teens CAGR, which leverages on the Group's network to support higher Fee & capital-light income, and deeper client penetration. We note that most of the Group's distribution is with Banks, compared to our previous expectation of NBFIs, and this should offer more sustainability in our view. Whilst there is limited appetite to enter into Equities, we note that FICC revenues are more capital-light given the focus on flow income. The Group expects overall CIB income to support a 5-7% income CAGR across FY25-28E, alongside further improvements in income/RWA.
- **AI to drive greater productivity:** The Group's Unified Enterprise Platform across 54 markets offers standardisation and greater connectivity across platforms which allows for greater productivity, more-informed risk management, and better data maneuverability (with 150 data lakes now consolidated into a single global data supply chain). The Group targets a 20% improvement in employee productivity by 28E, partly supported by a >15% reduction in Corporate functions headcount by 30E - which the Group expects will drive the CIR towards 57% in 28E.
- **Systems are future-proof:** In 4Q, the Group migrated to a global private cloud which offers 10x processing power and greater resilience to

disturbances (e.g. outages, geopolitical tensions). The Group also completed its HK mainframe migration in March to a global core banking platform, with >90% of markets now on a single platform (and Korea/Taiwan to move soon), offering greater agility for code deployment. The source code is also proprietary, removing reliance on third parties.

- **RMB internationalization will become an increasingly important driver of Markets income.** Policy support is aimed at expanding product availability and growing the stock of CNH assets held outside mainland China. The next major catalyst could be the roll out of dual-quoting for H-share companies listed in HK (which has already been approved). This could materially increase liquidity in RMB-denominated equity products offshore through the Connect programme, and reinforce RMB internationalisation following the recent surge in Dim Sum bond issuance.
- **Operate at the mid-point of the 13-14% target CET1 range, on average.** With increased capital generation expected across the plan (JPMe c210bps/y CET1 average from profits), capital use will be broadly split across dividends ($\geq 30\%$ div payout targeted vs JPMe 35%), RWA growth, and other capital uses with a hierarchy of buybacks, additional RWA growth opportunities to drive a higher trajectory of income growth, and inorganic opportunities. The Group is more confident in generating returns from RWA deployment, especially as Global Banking sub-optimal RWAs have declined c70% since 2019. On top of this, referring to STAN's guidance on revenue growth (5-7% CAGR 25-28E), CIR of ~57% by 2028 and credit cost through-the-cycle range of 30-35bps, we estimate that the net profit CAGR will be 12% from 2025 to 2028. Considering STAN's "high-teen" EPS growth guidance, we forecast a share count reduction of 13% in aggregate from 2025 to 2028, thus, we are comfortable with our share buyback assumption of \$2.0bn/\$2.5bn/\$2.5bn for FY26-28 respectively, with upside flexibility.

Figure 1: STAN's revised target in WRB business

Metrics	Existing target (2025-2029)	Revised target
Net new money Cumulative	\$200bn in 5 years	\$200bn in 4 years (2025-2028)
Wealth income CAGR	Double-digit 5-year CAGR	Double digit 3-year CAGR (2026-2028)
Affluent as a % of WRB income	75% by 2029 ¹	75% by 2028 ¹
Investment in Affluent Cumulative	\$1.5bn over 5 years	\$1.5bn over 5 years (2025-2029)

Source: Company reports.

Investment Thesis

We view StanChart as undervalued relative to the sector/EM peers at 1.3x PTNAV 27E with significant earnings growth potential supported by structural growth drivers and relatively high capital return. With the Group's 24-26E targets already achieved by FY25 across revenues and distributions, we now forecast ~6% revenue CAGR across '25-28E driven by non-NII in '26E, and broadening out to both NII/non-NII in outer years. We see this led by Wealth (driven by Affluent segment opportunities), Financial Markets (alongside cross-border income) and Banking. We expect NII to be largely flat in FY26 y/y due to lower rates and pass throughs offset by volume growth. We expect a ~1% cost CAGR for '25-28E as we expect growing investments in the future to capitalize on productivity and revenue opportunities, with positive operating leverage annually and the CIR to decline towards mid-50s. Overall, we expect stated ROTE to grow to ~15%, alongside a 35% dividend payout ratio and \$2-2.5bn/y buybacks, offering a total yield of 7-9%/y. Maintain OW.

Valuation

Our Dec-26 PT of HK\$275 is derived from our DDM analysis with NAV discounted back to Dec-26 from FY28E and a fair P/B of 1.5x. Our key assumptions are a normalized ROE of 12.1% and a cost of capital of 9.3%.

Risks to Rating and Price Target

The key downside risks to our rating and price target include:

- **Macroeconomic risks:** Being an EM-focused bank, StanChart is exposed to general macroeconomic risk in EM such as slowdowns, inflationary pressures, depreciation of EM currencies and cross-border and political risks. Potential weakness in China macro and regional sovereign continue to be risks towards revenues and impairments in the near term, as well as geopolitical tensions creating a potential headwind.
- **Provisioning outlook:** We expect provisions to grow to above normalized levels by 2025 given growing pressures in the economic environment. An increase or decrease in provisions as a result of the economic outlook or with regards to specific cases poses a risk to our forecasts.
- **Regulatory uncertainty:** Standard Chartered remains exposed to the changes in the regulatory environment in the UK with capital requirements being set by the PRA in the UK. While StanChart has limited UK exposure, the group is still subject to regulatory changes such as Basel 4 and BoE stress tests.

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Standard Chartered Plc (HK) (2888) (2888.HK, 2888 HK) Price Chart



Source: Bloomberg Finance L.P. and J.P. Morgan; price data adjusted for stock splits and dividends.
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Date	Rating	Price (HK\$)	Price Target (HK\$)
07-Jul-23	OW	66.55	83
01-Aug-23	OW	74.25	90
07-Sep-23	OW	69.20	91
27-Oct-23	OW	59.75	83
16-Jan-24	OW	61.55	79
18-Jan-24	OW	57.35	78
28-Feb-24	OW	63.35	80
10-Apr-24	OW	68.25	82
03-May-24	OW	71.95	86
31-Jul-24	OW	76.90	94
04-Dec-24	OW	96.80	112
17-Feb-25	OW	108.20	120
24-Feb-25	OW	116.00	135
22-Jul-25	OW	141.30	148
04-Aug-25	OW	141.30	162
19-Oct-25	OW	142.00	168
03-Nov-25	OW	157.80	190
05-Feb-26	OW	203.40	265
01-Mar-26	OW	198.50	270
03-May-26	OW	190.80	275

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